A WIDE SWEEP
Rahul takes the stage at the plenary

That too has been done before—at the Udaipur Chintan Shivir last May. Many of the resolutions adopted then, particularly about filling up all vacant posts within three to six months, lie unfulfilled. "Forget district and pradesh Congress committees (PCCs), even Mallikarjun Kharge may keep some positions vacant to play a carrot and stick policy," says a senior Congress leader. The Congress steering committee unanimously decided not to hold elections to constitute the CWC and instead empowered party president Kharge to nominate all the members, a tradition that has continued for the past 25 years since Sonia Gandhi took charge.

So while the goody-goody vocabulary flows freely, the Congress has yet to showcase clarity and conviction in real time. Shashi Tharoor minced no words when he said the party should clearly stand up for its ideological founding principles when it matters. The tendency to downplay or avoid taking a stand on some issues to not alienate the assumed sentiments of the majority, he argued, only plays into the BJP's hands. "We must have the courage of our convictions. We could have been more vocal on the Bilkis Bano outrage, attacks on churches, murder in the name of cow vigilantism, bulldozer demolition of Muslim homes and other such issues," he said.

The party is also yet to iron out some inherent contradictions. It was the Congress that introduced liberalisation in India in 1991, helping Indian industry expand. Yet, the party's constant jibes against corporate India give it a Leftist hue—as if it's fundamentally opposed to private enterprise. Currently, the Congress plans to remind the people of its role in liberalisation, but its biggest agitation agenda revolves around the allegations against Gautam Adani, and his relationship with the PM is being seen as the Congress's biggest weapon going into the 2024 general election. Simultaneously, its stated intention is apparently to fight elections on local issues, not around Modi. The Congress seems to remember how its 2019 slogan 'Chowkidar chor hai', alleging the PM's involvement in a putative Rafale scam, fell flat—and at the same time seems to forget it. ■



BHUSHAN KOYANDE

RESERVATION RALLY
Protesters from the Matang cohort in Mumbai over quota

SC reservation, will protect their interests. Buddhist Dalit leaders are opposed to any such idea.

In Maharashtra, the SC category has 59 castes listed under it, and Buddhist Dalits form the highest numbers among them. In all, the SCs constitute around 13 per cent of the state's population.

The discontent is spilling out into the streets. On February 22, organisations of the Matang community held a protest in Mumbai to press for this demand.

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